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DOWNSTREAM FROM TECHNOLOGY

Many years ago, when my daughter Debra was nine years old, I read her the old, comfortable children's book *Mary Poppins*. It's filled with fantastic adventures, but the strangest part of it to me was what the author accepted as plain matter of fact.

The book opens by describing the Banks family as rather ordinary middle class: "Number Seventeen . . . is the smallest house in the lane . . . rather dilapidated and in need of a coat of paint. But Mr. Banks, who owns it, said to Mrs. Banks that she could have either a nice, clean, comfortable house or four children. But not both, for he couldn't afford it."

In this semislum, we find the family faced with a crisis: the nursemaid has quit, and the family is being forced to get by short-handed, with only a cook, a maid, and a houseboy. Luckily, Mary Poppins shows up and allows Mrs. Banks to avoid having to touch her own children.

The time when it took four servants to run an ordinary household seems very far away. Now we have machines instead of houseboys and housegirls. A revolution in energy use has transformed household productivity, transportation, industry, and just about everything else. It would be no exaggeration to say there would